

ROSES

Prized for their beauty and fragrance, roses are considered the most romantic of flowers. They are indispensable in informal mixed planting schemes, and add an elegant note to formal parterres. With thousands of colors and forms to choose from, there is a rose for every garden.

Growing roses

With some 150 species and thousands of cultivars, both ancient and modern, there are members of the genus *Rosa* to suit an enormous number of garden situations. They come from a wide range of habitats throughout the northern hemisphere and, with few exceptions, most roses are very hardy. Many modern roses combine the best qualities of old roses, such as flower shape and scent, with disease resistance and extended flowering seasons.

When grown in a suitable site and soil, they will repay you with a profusion of blooms. All roses prefer an open, sunny site in fertile, humus-rich, moist but well-drained soil. However, avoid planting them in an area where roses have been grown before because the soil may be affected by "rose sickness," caused by a buildup of harmful soil organisms, and plants may fail to thrive. Roses also require a good supply

of nutrients to perform well, and benefit from an annual application of all-purpose granular fertilizer in the spring.

Year-round interest

Although some roses, notably the ramblers and species, bloom for a relatively short period, many hybrids are repeat-flowering, providing a colorful display throughout the summer. 'Frühlingsmorgen' offers the first flush of flowers in early summer, followed by the main flourish from mid-summer to the first frost. To help maintain this display, deadhead your roses regularly, as this redirects the plant's energy from seed formation to flower production. However, if you want attractive fruits (hips) in the fall, leave the blooms to fade. The best roses for hips include the Rugosa's tomato-like fruit, the flask-shaped, vibrant scarlet fruits of *R. moyesii*, and the rounded, black hips of *R. pimpinellifolia*.

Ornamental features

Roses embrace almost every color of the spectrum, apart from true blue, and some have a strong fragrance, such as the heady, sweet scent of the Damasks or musk and spicy fragrances of many modern roses. A few also have ornamental thorns, notably *R. sericea* subsp. *omeiensis* f. *pteracantha*, with its large, triangular thorns that glow blood-red when they are backlit.

Foliage can also provide interest. The soft gray-purple leaves of *R. glauca* and blue-green of the Alba roses provide attractive foils for crimson and purple flowers, while foliage textures, ranging from glossy to matte, and delicate fernlike to robustly wrinkled, as in *R. rugosa*, create beautiful contrasts.

Designing with roses

Roses have a diversity of habits, each of which can be used to create exciting designs. These include mound-forming groundcover roses, densely thorny Gallicas, and the arching Chinas and Damasks. A traditional rose garden laid out in a formal style with geometrically ordered beds is particularly suited to the upright growth of many bush roses.



ABOVE Container roses

Some roses have been bred specifically for containers, such as the patio rose *REGENSBURG*. Partner them with trailing annuals, such as *Chaenostoma cordatum*.

LEFT Formal dressing

Here, a sturdy arch clothed with clematis and a vigorous, free-flowering rambler lends height to the scheme and forms a perfect frame to draw the eye to the sculpture used as a focal point.

